

A WEEKEND PROJECT

Teaching a tool to someone who has never opened it

I learned Whatfix (Community edition) and built in-app guidance for Google Data Studio: a 12-step walkthrough, a Beacon, and a Self Help panel.

Alisha Chaudhari · Digital adoption / Product

The problem I was solving

Google Data Studio is free and powerful. It is also a blank canvas, and a blank canvas is where new users quit.

So I did not document the product. I picked the single journey that makes the tool click — getting your own data onto a page and seeing it become a chart — and built guidance for that one journey.

Rule I worked to: guide the task that is high-volume or expensive to get wrong. Let the obvious stuff go.

Three pieces

01 Walkthrough

All 12 steps, from the Create button to a shared report.

02 Top 5 flows

The next five journeys a beginner needs, ordered as a funnel.

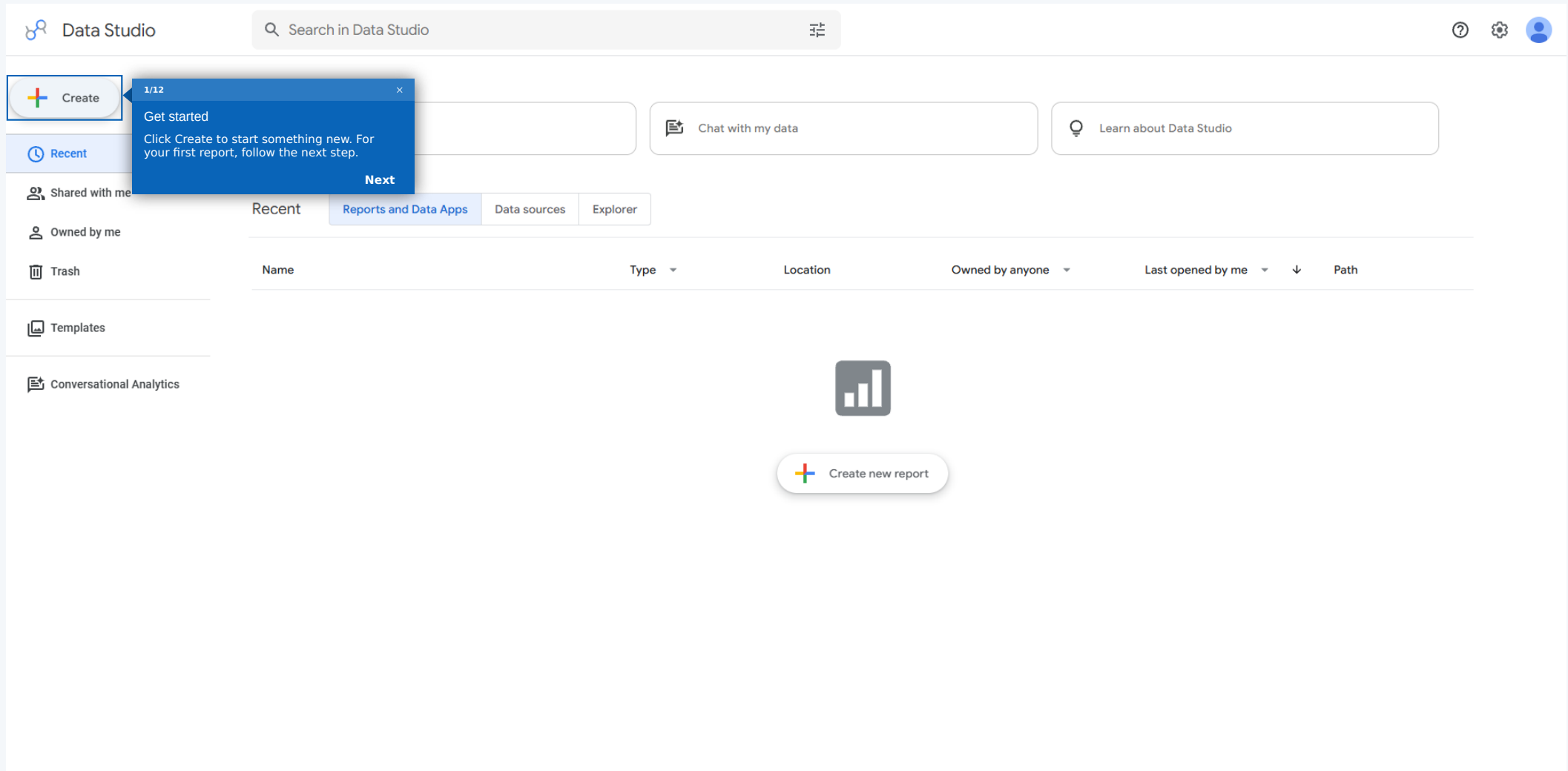
03 Beacon + Self Help

One nudge to a feature people miss, and a help panel so the guidance never runs out.

PART ONE

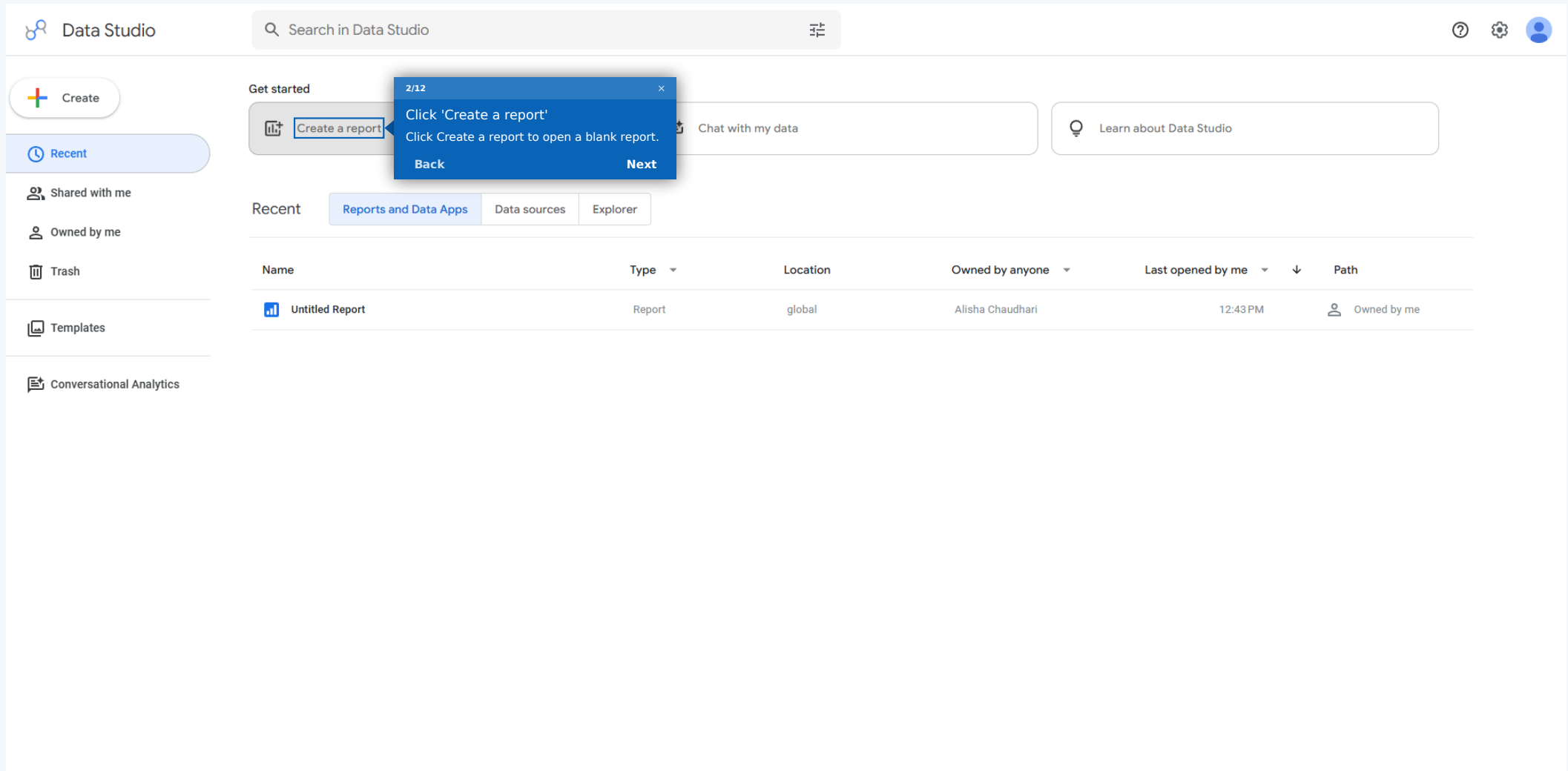
The walkthrough, step by step

Every screen a first-time user sees. Twelve steps, no side-trips.



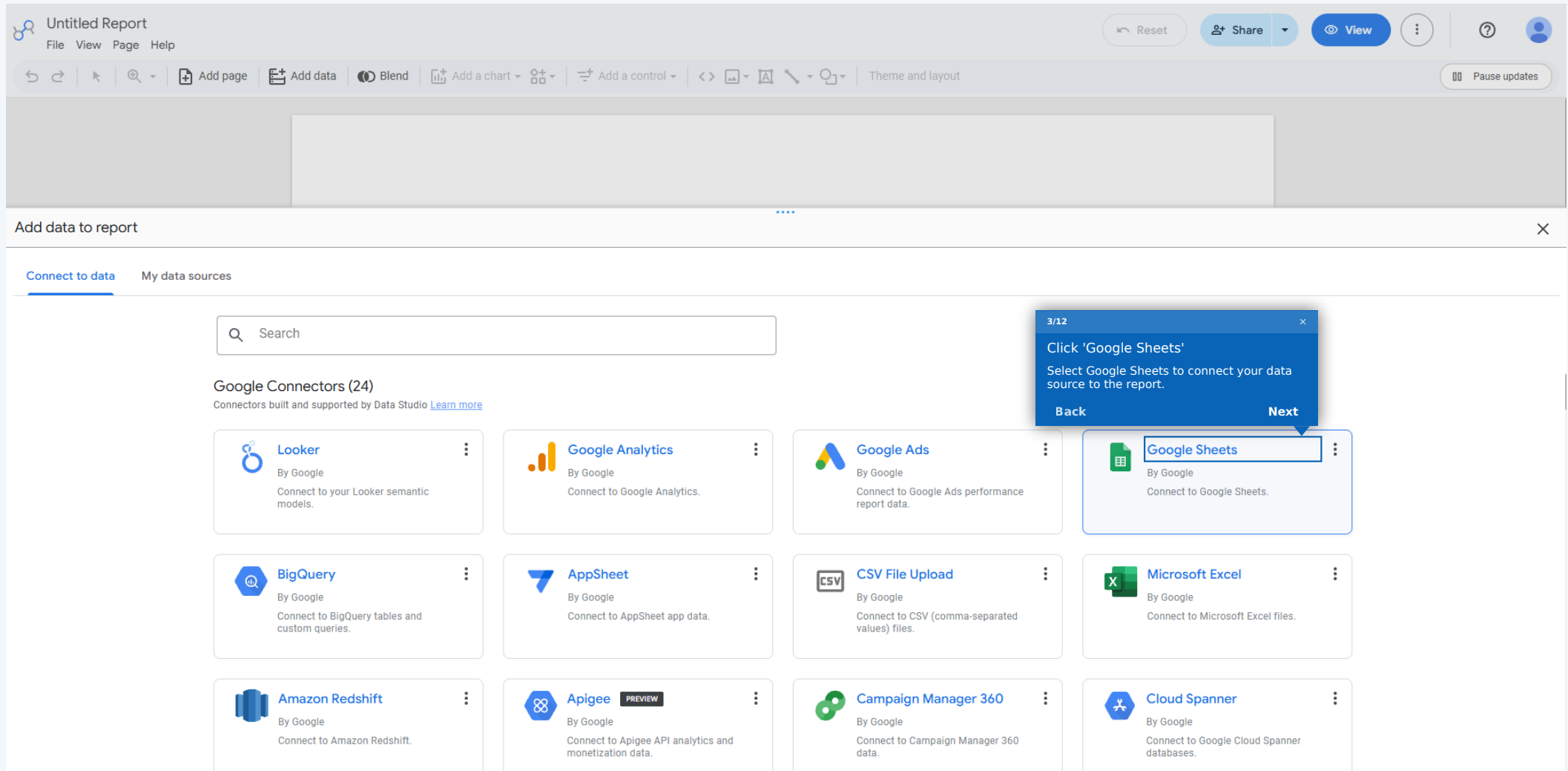
Step 1 · Click Create

Start where every new user lands. Two clicks and they are inside the editor.



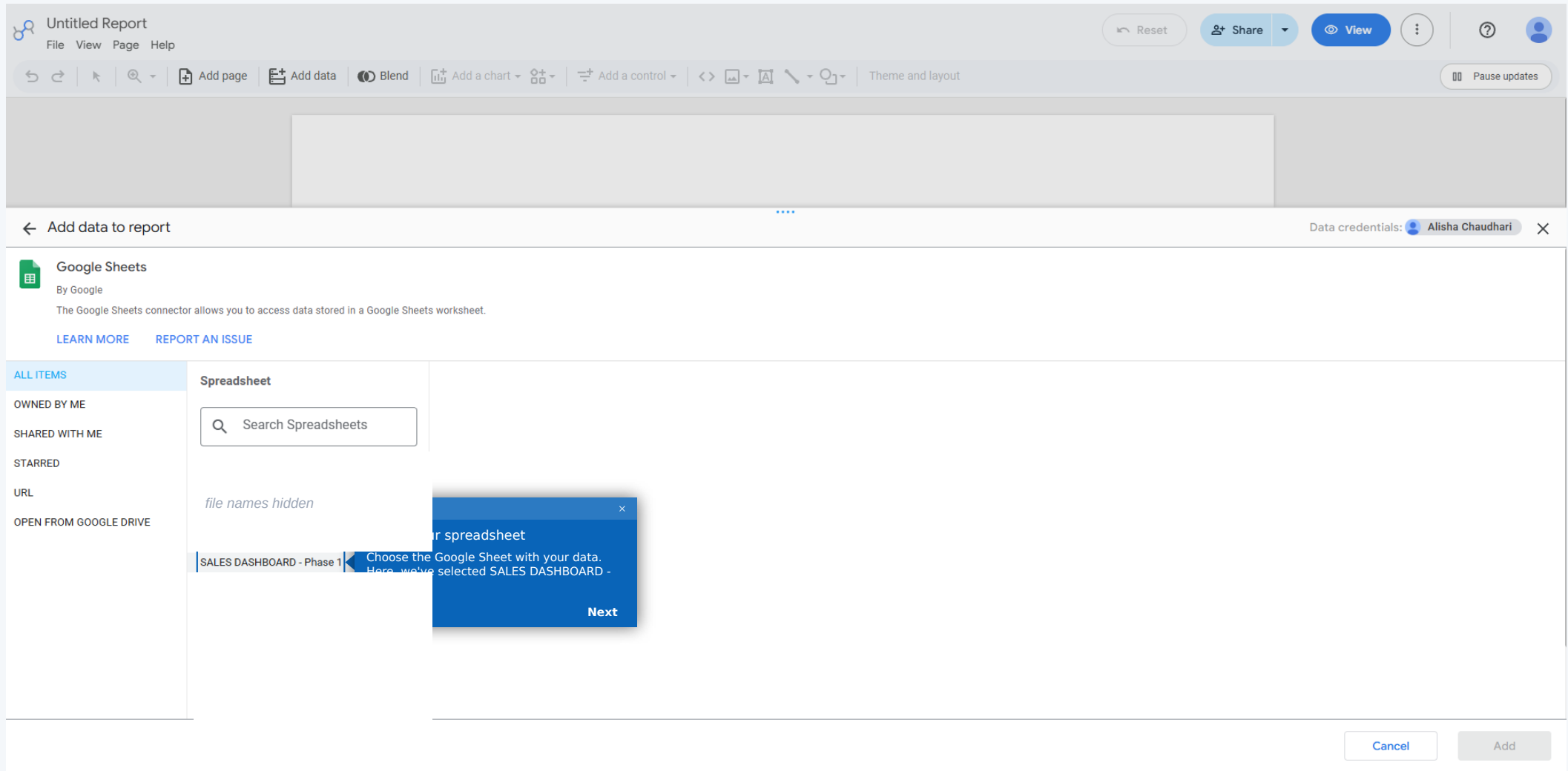
Step 2 · Create a report

Straight to a blank report — no detour through templates or settings.



Step 3 · Choose Google Sheets

A beginner already has a Google account and a sheet. Other connectors add credentials, and credentials are where people quit.



Step 4 · Select your spreadsheet

A real sheet, not a demo file — guidance is trusted when it looks like your own screen.

Untitled Report

FileViewPageHelp

ResetShareView

UndoRedoMoveZoomAdd pageAdd dataBlendAdd a chartAdd a controlAdd a controlTheme and layoutPause updates

←Add data to reportData credentials: Alisha Chaudhari×

LEARN MOREREPORT AN ISSUE

ALL ITEMSOWNED BY MESHARED WITH MESTARREDURLOPEN FROM GOOGLE DRIVE

Spreadsheet

Search Spreadsheet

file names hidden

SALES DASHBOARD - Phase 1

5/12

Select a worksheet

Choose the tab you want to use. Here, we've selected CUSTOMER.

BackNext

CUSTOMER

LEADS

REVENUE - Subscription

REVENUE - Trial Pipeline

REVENUE - Products

REVENUE - Invoices

Email

Live Chat

Operations - Daily Ops

Operations - Cases

Operations - Activities

Operations - Sync

SEPERATE DASHBOARD

GUIDE/ DICTIONARY

Copy of FEATURES

Copy of PRD

Options

☒ Use first row as headers

Column headers must be unique.

Columns with empty headers will not be added to the data source.

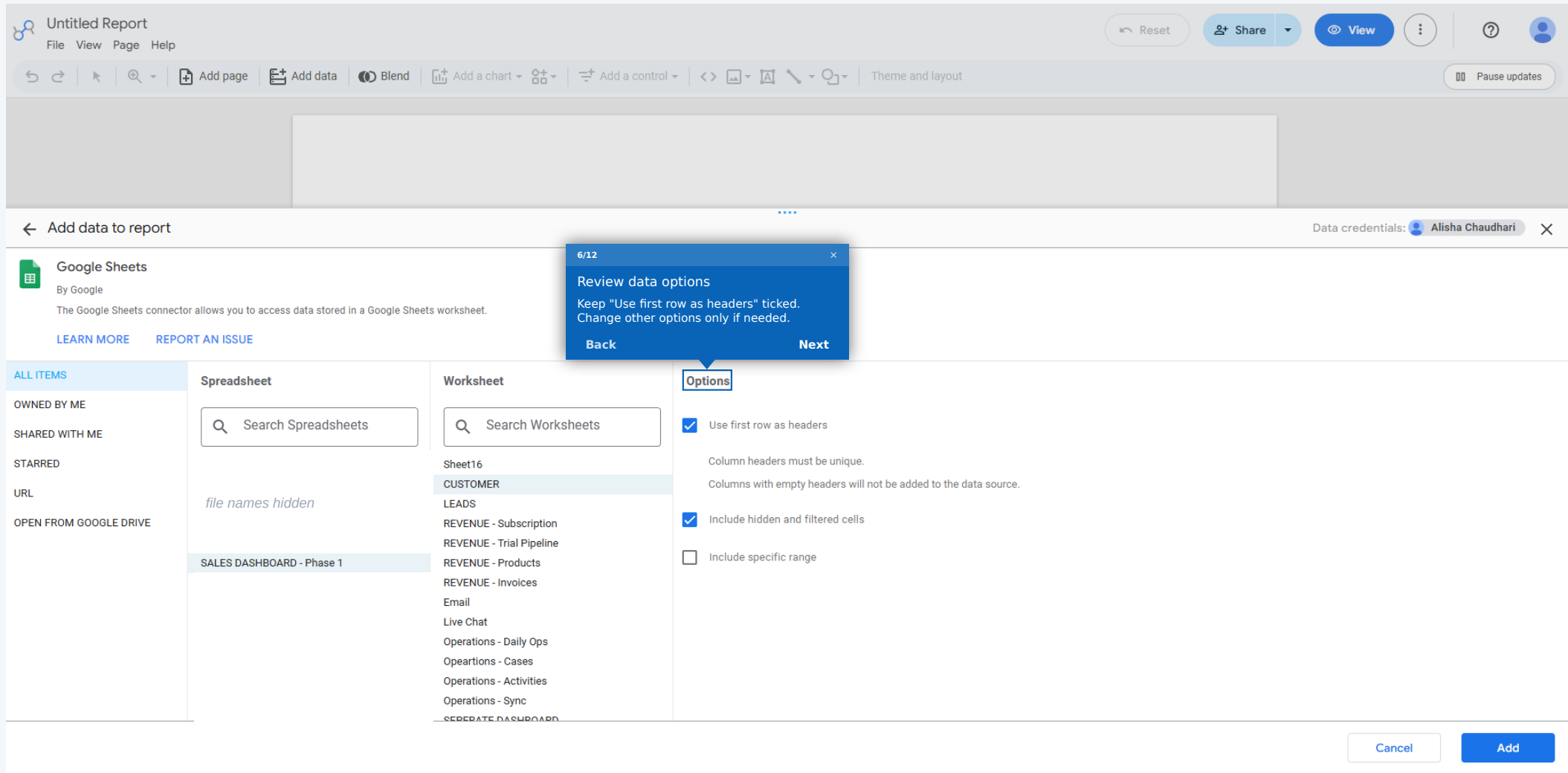
☒ Include hidden and filtered cells

☐ Include specific range

CancelAdd

Step 5 · Select a worksheet

One tab, one data source. Saying which tab stops the "which one was it?" question later.



Step 6 · Review data options

The silent failure. If "use first row as headers" is unticked, every field is named wrongly and the user thinks the tool is broken.

Untitled Report

FileViewPageHelp

Reset

Share

View

↶↷↵🔍

Add page

Add data

Blend

Add a chart

Add a control

<>🖼️📐🔗

Theme and layout

Pause updates

←Add data to report

Data credentials: Alisha Chaudhari

ALL ITEMS

OWNED BY ME

SHARED WITH ME

STARRED

URL

OPEN FROM GOOGLE DRIVE

Spreadsheet

Search Spreadsheets

file names hidden

SALES DASHBOARD - Phase 1

Worksheet

Search Worksheets

Sheet16

CUSTOMER

LEADS

REVENUE - Subscription

REVENUE - Trial Pipeline

REVENUE - Products

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SEPERATE DASHBOARD

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7/12

Click 'Add'

Click Add to connect the selected data to your report.

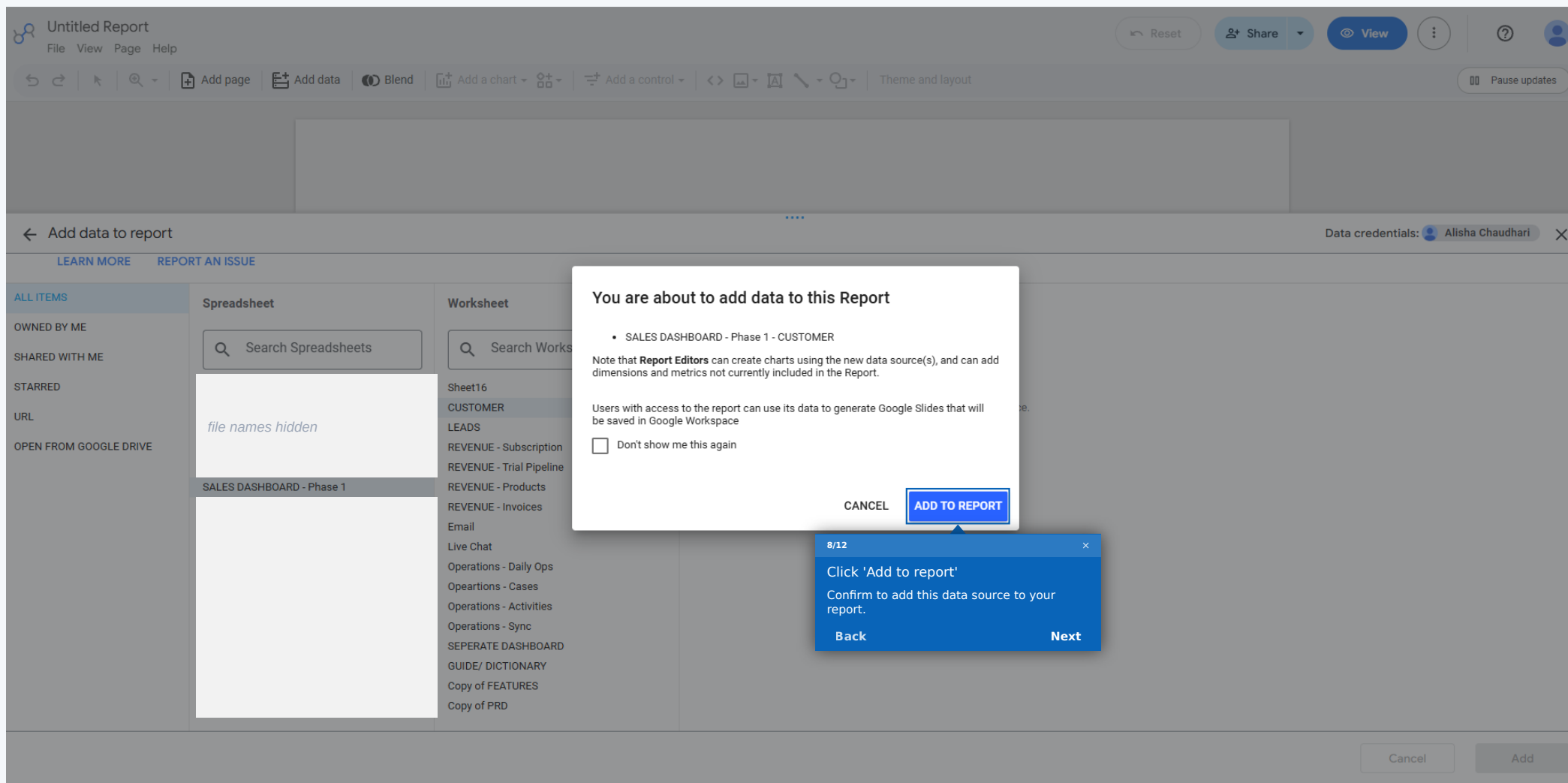
BackNext

Cancel

Add

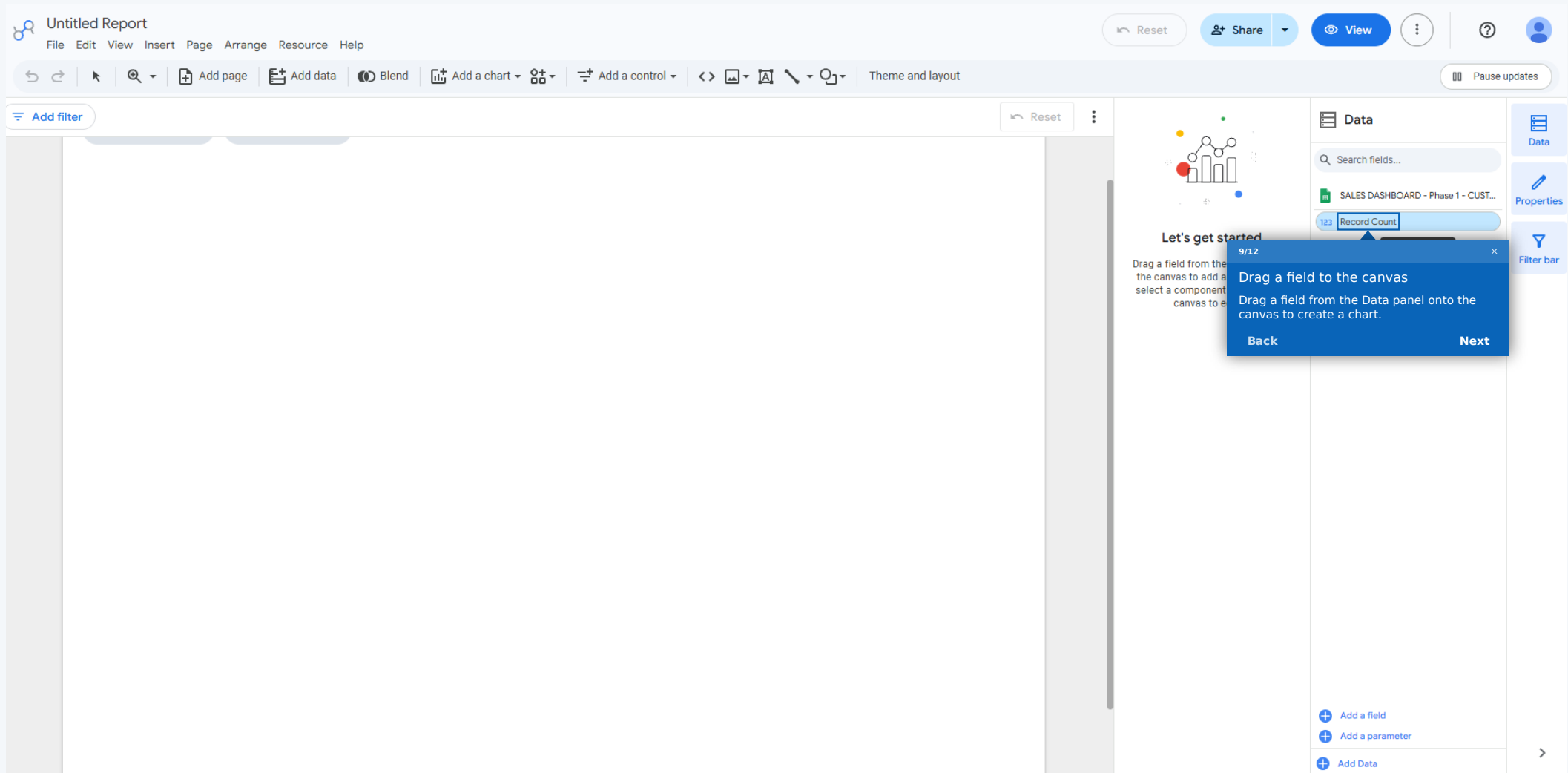
Step 7 · Click Add

Two confirmations in a row is where people hesitate — so each one gets its own step.



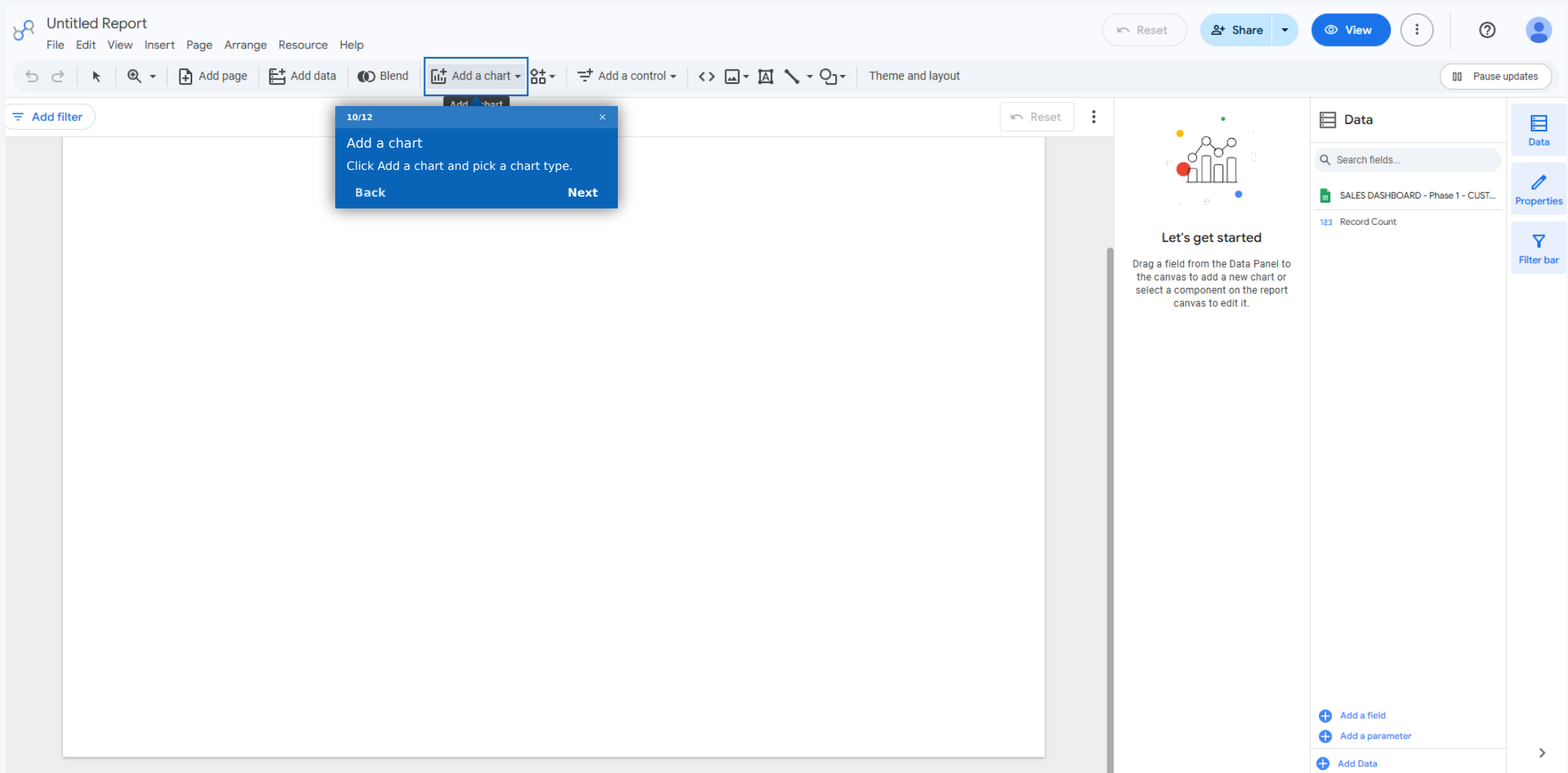
Step 8 · Add to report

Confirm, and the data source is attached to the report.



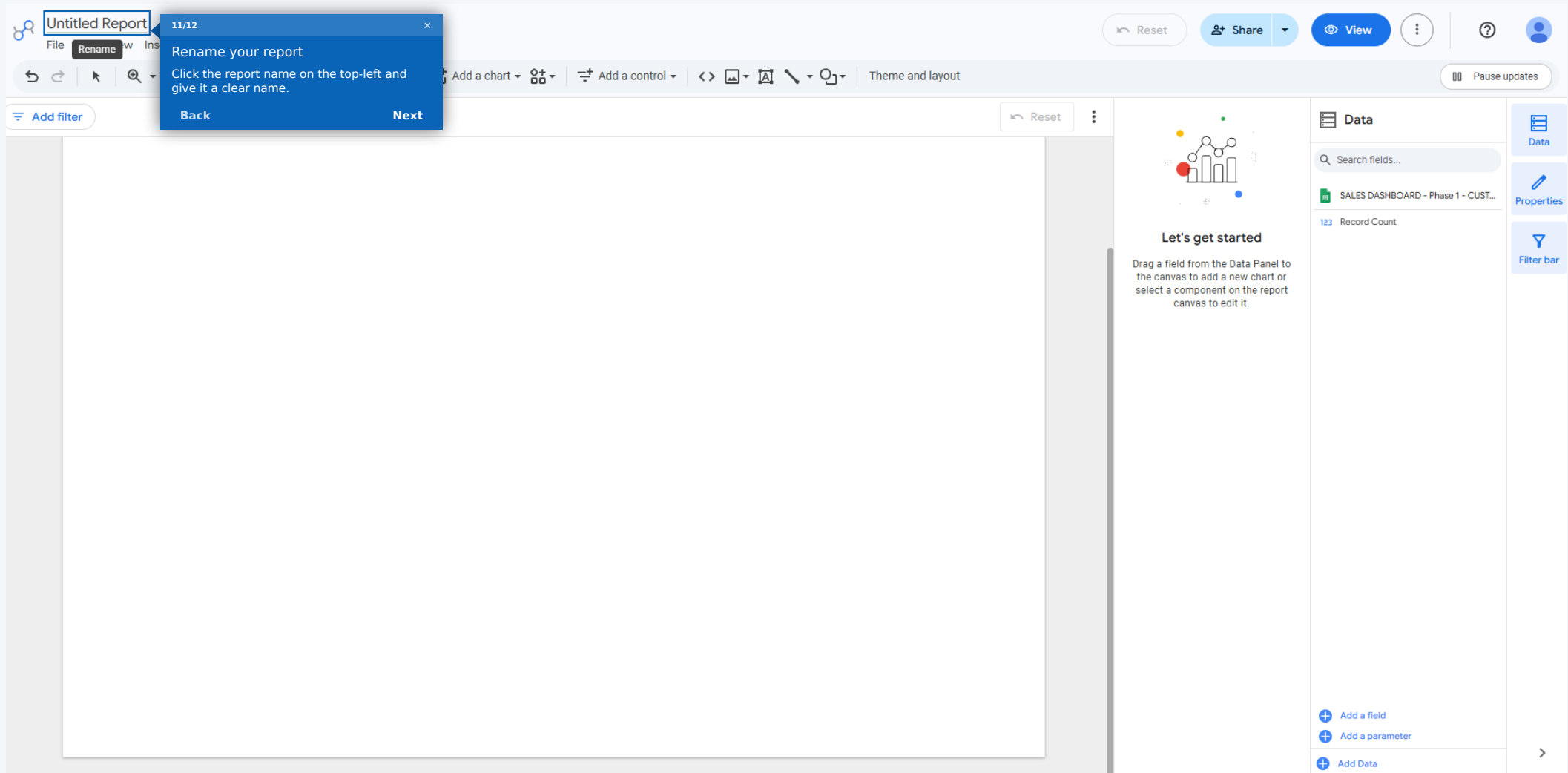
Step 9 · Drag a field to the canvas

The first time the user makes something appear. This is the turning point.



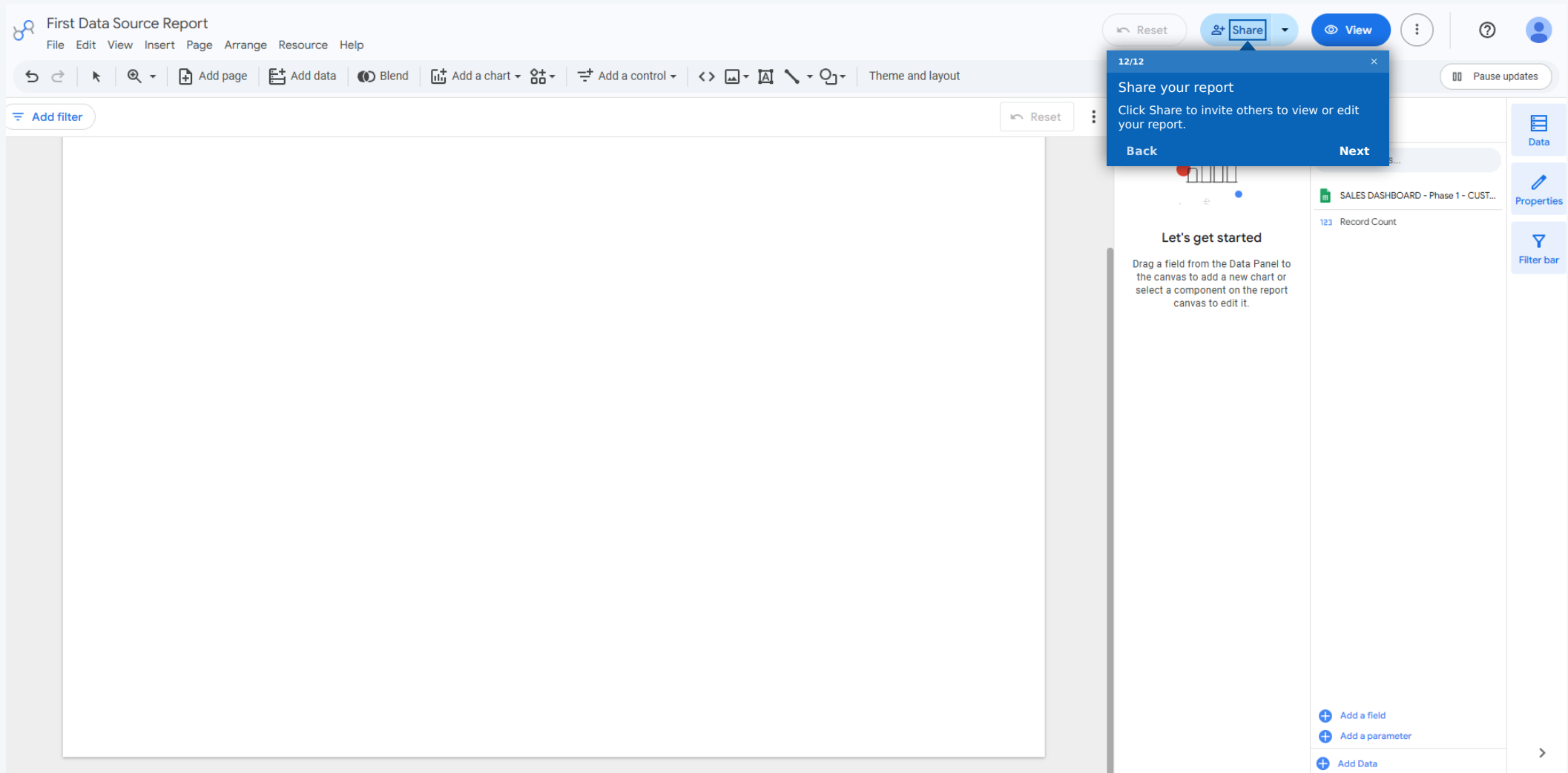
Step 10 · Add a chart

Data becomes a picture. This is the moment the tool clicks.



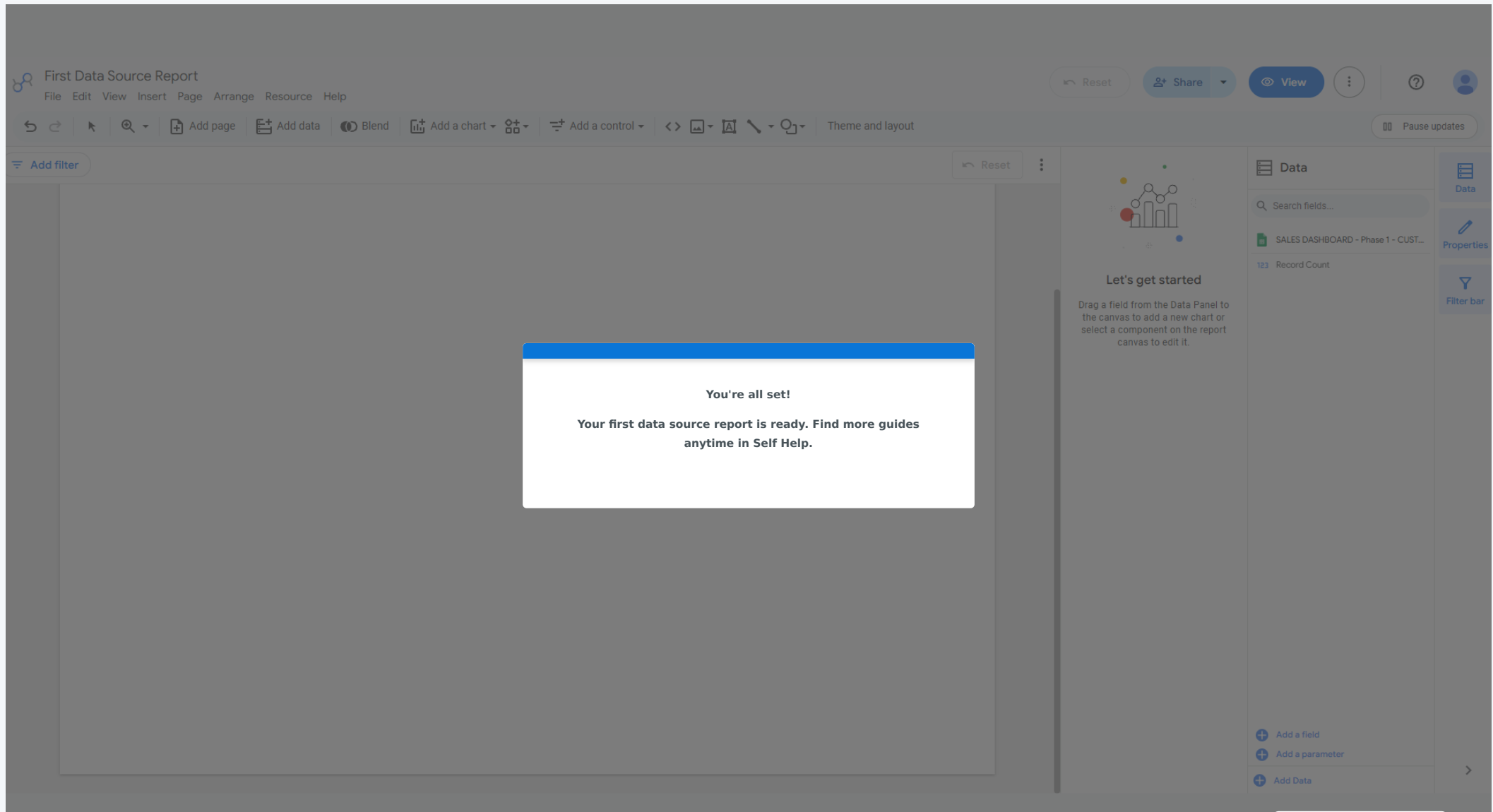
Step 11 · Rename your report

Small, but it is how the user finds this again tomorrow.



Step 12 · Share your report

It ends on sharing, not on "now explore" — a report nobody sees gets abandoned by Friday.



Done — and handed over

The last screen points at Self Help. The walkthrough ends; the user's questions do not.

PART TWO

Top 5 flows for a new user

A funnel, not a menu. Each one is the next place a beginner gets stuck.

01

Create your first report

The core aha moment. Users who build one report early are far more likely to come back.

HOW TO DO IT

1. Click Create > Report.
2. Pick a connector, select your data, click Add > Add to report.
3. Click Untitled Report to rename it. It saves automatically.

02

Connect and manage a data source

Every chart depends on it. Wrong field types or stale credentials cause most "my numbers look wrong" tickets.

HOW TO DO IT

1. Click Create > Data source, then choose a connector (e.g. Google Sheets).
2. Select the file, click Connect.
3. Check each field's data type and aggregation; use Add a field for calculated fields.
4. Use Refresh fields when the source changes.



03

Start from a template

Beginners freeze at a blank canvas. Templates show good design and cut setup time.

HOW TO DO IT

1. Click Templates in the left menu.
2. Filter by category and open one.
3. Click Use my own data, then pick your data source.
4. Click Edit and share to save it as your own report.

04

Add charts and interactive controls

Filters and date ranges turn a static page into a dashboard people can explore.

HOW TO DO IT

1. Click Add a chart, choose a type, drag it onto the canvas.
2. In the Setup panel, set Dimension and Metric.
3. Click Add a control > Date range control or Drop-down list.
4. Click View to test it the way a viewer sees it.

05

Share and schedule a report

Reports create value only when others see them. Scheduling keeps stakeholders updated without extra effort.

HOW TO DO IT

1. Click Share > add people > Can view or Can edit > Send.
2. Or open the Share drop-down > Get report link > Copy link.
3. From the same drop-down, choose Schedule delivery.
4. Set recipients and frequency, then click Schedule.

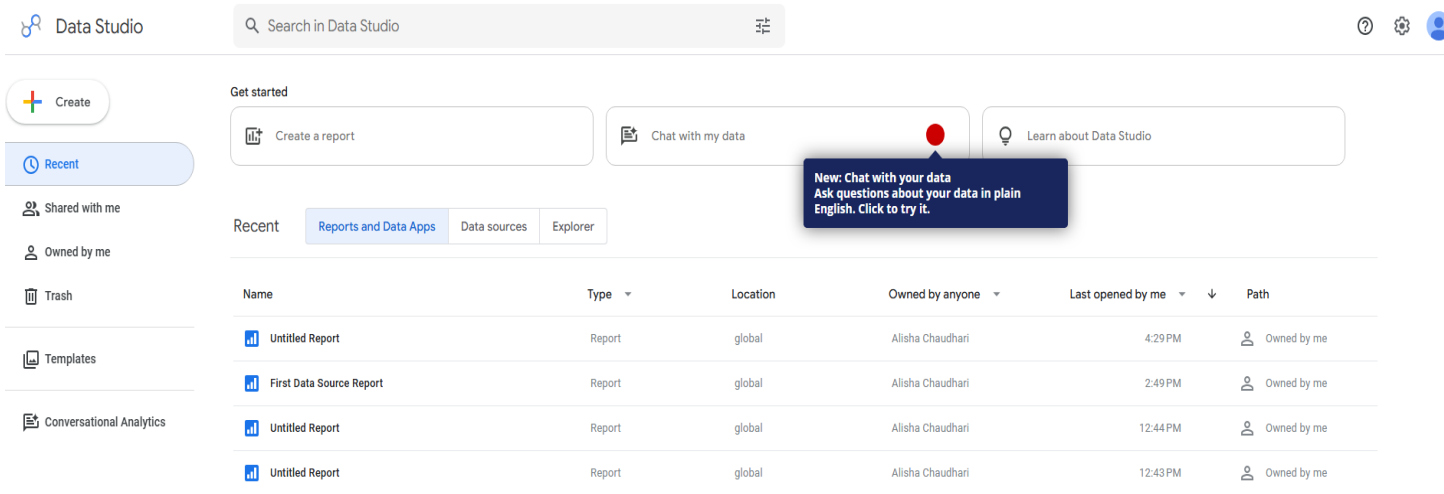
PART THREE

Beacon and Self Help

One nudge towards a feature people miss, and a help panel so support never runs out.

Beacon

A pulsing hotspot that draws the eye to one element, without blocking the user.



Example: A beacon on the "Chat with my data" card tells users about this new feature on the Data Studio home page.

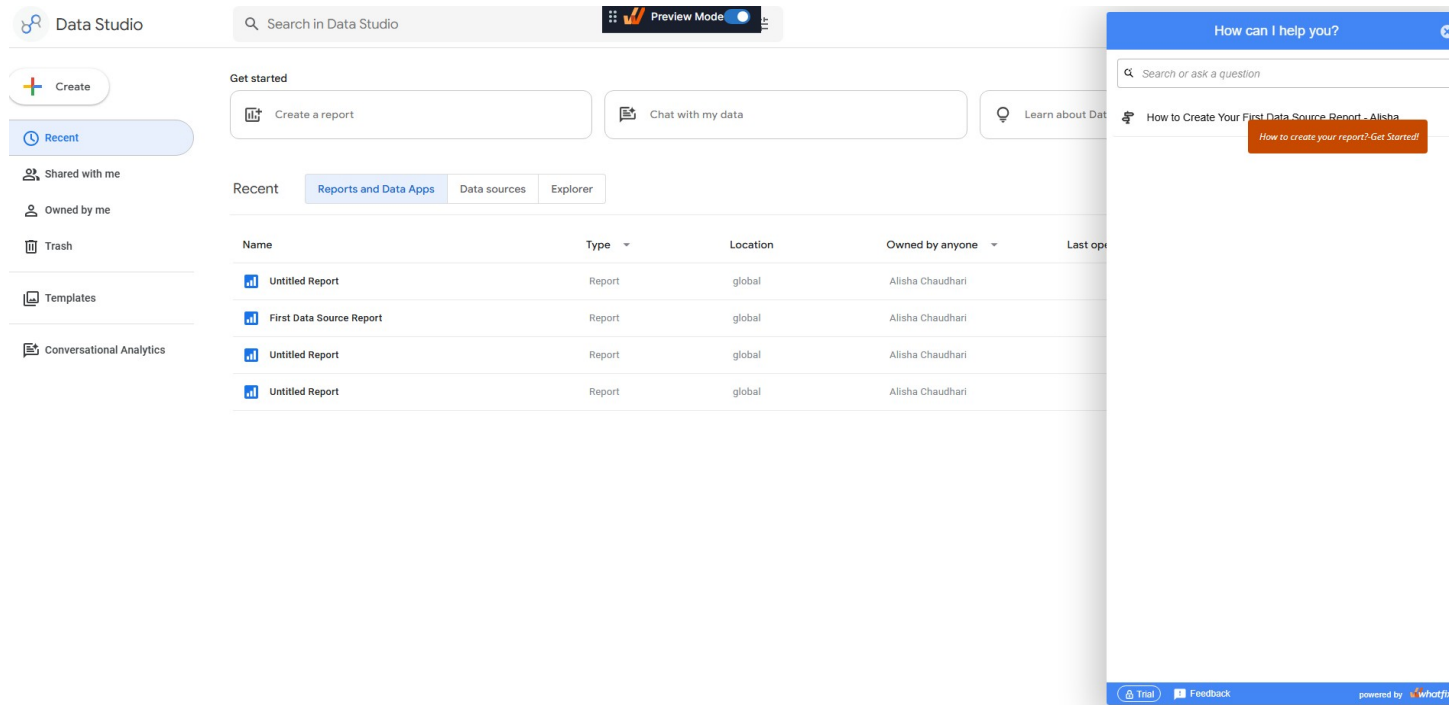
Use cases

- **Highlight a new feature:** point users to something new, like "Chat with my data".
- **Promote a useful feature:** remind users about tools they often miss, like Templates or Schedule delivery.
- **Show what changed:** mark a button or menu that moved or looks different after an update.
- **Offer more help:** let users click the beacon to start a step-by-step guide.

Set-up in Whatfix: Studio → Beacon → select "Chat with my data" → add tooltip text → set visibility (Data Studio domain; shows when the card is on screen; all users; up to 5 times) → Save.

Self Help

An in-app help widget: users search and launch guides, articles and videos without leaving Data Studio.



Example: The Self Help panel on the Data Studio home page lists the "How to Create Your First Data Source Report" walkthrough.

Use cases

- **Help at the moment of need:** users can ask questions like "How do I create a report?" without leaving Data Studio.
- **All help in one place:** walkthroughs, help articles and videos sit in a single panel.
- **Faster start, fewer tickets:** new users build their first report on their own, so they send fewer support requests.
- **Right help on the right page:** each page can show only the guides that fit it, like report guides inside the report editor.

Set-up in Whatfix: Dashboard → Widget → Create Widget → Self Help → add the walkthrough → set visibility (URL contains datastudio.google.com) → Save.

What I would measure next

- Completion rate of the walkthrough — and the exact step people quit at.
- Time to first report created, per new user.
- Support questions about building a report, before and after.
- Help searches that return nothing — that list is the next thing to write.

Content without a number attached is just documentation with animation.

What I took away

Building the guidance was the fast part. Deciding what to leave out took longer than recording the steps.

Software is not hard to buy. It is hard to get used.

Full write-up and files: github.com/ALISHA-19/gds-digital-adoption-case-study

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